You could be happy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25239790.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), catradora - Relationship

Character:
Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), She-Ra (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Princess Alliance (She-Ra) - Character, Horde Soldiers (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Crimson Waste, Fluff and Angst, Angst, Fluff, Slow Burn, Divergence AU

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2020-07-13 Completed: 2020-07-19 Words: 7,956 Chapters: 5/5

You could be happy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25239790.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), catradora - Relationship

Character:
Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), She-Ra (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Princess Alliance (She-Ra) - Character, Horde Soldiers (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Crimson Waste, Fluff and Angst, Angst, Fluff, Slow Burn, Divergence AU

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2020-07-13 Completed: 2020-07-19 Words: 7,956
Chapters: 5/5

You could be happy

by itisprobablynot

Summary

"Catra, you have to let me go." Adora wasn't pleading but demanding. This did not sit well with Catra. Her smirk faltered for a split second before coming back twice as strong.

"There's always something with you, isn't there Adora." Catra crouched before her prisoner, cupping her cheek with a clawed hand. "See the thing is, I don't have to do anything anyone tells me to anymore." Adora's eyes widened a little but kept her eyes trained on Catra who took this as an encouragement to continue.

"I'm in control out here. This is my land now. And you," Catra's gentle hand turned harsh, grabbing Adora's chin earning a slight gasp. "Well, you are just an inconvenience."

OR

Catra decides to ditch the Horde and take the place as Ruler of the Crimson Waste

A gentle grip

Chapter Notes

> Yoooo I made a Twitter just for my fan stuff. Give it a follow if you want! I'm trying to be more active in the SPOP community and I'm finally finding some motivation to write some more so give it a follow if you want:)
>
> @_artisweird

"Why wouldn't we go back?" Catra looked up at Scorpia towering over her. It wasn't intimidating, Catra was not entirely sure intimation was in Scoripa's abilities. Her ridiculously larger friend offered a comfort, not that Catra would ever admit that out loud. She would never hear the end of it.

But when Scorpia suggested that they stay in the Crimson waste together, it made Catra feel extremely uncomfortable. Could she really ditch the horde, everything she has worked for, to lead a gang of misfits and criminals? It's not that she didn't want to. In fact, Catra could see herself being fairly content with her new place of power. But could she leave behind the only place she has ever called home? Forget all about Hordak and his ruthless plans. Forget about the black garnet and the intense feeling of unease she felt just thinking about it and the chamber it inhabited. Forget about Shadow weaver. Forget about *her*.

"Because you're miserable there!" Scorpia gently placed her monstrous claws on Catra's small shoulders, bending down a little to meet Catra's eyes. "I have never seen you as happy as when you're out there, leading them. Actually, I've never seen you happy. Until now."

Catra looked away. The gentle eye contact was getting too much. It was true, the last time she was this happy was way before she had even met Scorpia. In fact, the last memory that matched the happiness Catra felt now, was when *she* was still in the Horde.

They had made it out to the roof top to watch the blood red sunset. As disgusting and mank as the Fright Zone is, in that moment with legs hanging over the edge and hands barely touching, everything was beautiful.

She was beautiful.

Catra's grip on that stupid sword tightened. She had been unconsciously cradling it to her chest.

"Come on, Wildcat." Catra bit her cheek to suppress a sneer at the nickname Scorpia had taken a liking to. "We could thrive out here. You could thrive out here. We could leave it all behind." Catra met Scorpia's eyes once again, they were so full of a fiery hope. She didn't think it was right to stamp that fire out.

Noticing how close they had got, Catra shrugged Scorpia's claws off of her and took a few steps back. The larger woman looked deflated but quickly regained that hope when Catra held the sword out for her to take.

"Do not lose this. I'm going to check on Ado… on the prisoner." Scorpia nodded eagerly and gently took the sword from Catra who turned to leave. Before she reached the door to where they were keeping the prisoner, she looked over her shoulder to Scorpia who was staring after her. A faint blush crept onto Catra's cheeks. "Go and enjoy the party, Scorpia. I will be back soon." Without waiting for a reply, she left the room. Scorpia let out a squeal of joy before re-joining the party, the sword in a secure grip.

Adora was still tied to one of the many posts protruding from the ship's structure, struggling to break free from her confines. Catra stayed in the shadows by the door, taking in the scene before her. The powerful She-ra tied up in her own ship, powerless to the mighty Horde force captain. She snickered to herself before sauntering over to the prisoner.

"*Hey, Adora*." Catra smirked down at the prisoner who only glared back at her, a thin layer of sweat coating her forehead probably

from all of the struggling. Catra nodded towards the gang member who was keeping guard. He nodded back respectfully and left without a word.

“Catra, you have to let me go.” Adora wasn’t pleading but demanding. This did not sit well with Catra. Her smirk faltered for a split second before coming back twice as strong.

“There’s always something with you, isn’t there Adora.” Catra crouched before her prisoner, cupping her cheek with a clawed hand. “See the thing is, I don’t have to do anything anyone tells me to anymore.” Adora’s eyes widened a little but kept her eyes trained on Catra who took this as an encouragement to continue.

“I’m in control out here. This is my land now. And you,” Catra’s gentle hand turned harsh, grabbing Adora’s chin earning a slight gasp. “Well, you are just an inconvenience.”

A very brief flash of hurt could be clearly seen in Adora’s eyes but that was quickly replaced with the same determined look every princess in the rebellion seemed to have. Even that arrow boy. Catra wanted to break Adora’s pretty face just to get rid of that look.

“What are you going to do with me?” Adora’s voice was low but hard. Catra had to stop herself flinching from the harshness but quickly shook her head. No, she was in control here. She will not let some idiotic princess take that away from her. Even if that particular princess was her ex-best friend. Catra stood up, never breaking eye contact with the woman knelt before her. It made her feel powerful.

“Whatever the hell I want.” Catra snarled before turning to walk away.

“My friends will come back for me,” Catra stopped, her hands turning to fists by her side. “They’ll stop you before you hand me over to Hordak. You know they will. We always stop you.” There was a hint of desperation in Adora’s words. Good.

“Who said anything about giving you to Hordak?” Her own words were strong, final. Catra glanced over her shoulder to a confused Adora whose tension in her binds seemed to falter.

“What?” Catra strode over to Adora again, gripping her collar bringing their faces closer together.

“Hordak will not lay a finger on you.” There was a hidden promise between those words. The same words that Adora had whispered to her in their shared bunk when they were kids after Shadow Weaver had threatened for a higher power to deal with Catra’s disappointing tendencies. She hoped that Adora would not remember the meaning behind the words but judging by the recognition on her face, it was safe to presume she did. Catra growled tightening her grip on Adora’s collar.

“The Horde will not touch you. Neither will the rebellion. You are *my* prisoner. For once, I hold the upper hand. I have their almighty She-ra.” Catra brought her lips to Adora’s ear. She could hear the blonde’s breath stagger a little. “You are mine.”

Catra shoved Adora away from her, stepping back. Adora’s face was flushed but her eyebrows were deeply furrowed, a frown was very much evident. Before Adora could retaliate, the door swooshed open revealing an ecstatic Scorpia, the sword still in her firm grip.

“Catra, you have to come try this drink! It’s so sweet an-
“Scorpia’s rambling was cut short as she took in the scene before her. Adora’s face still held that tint of pink. “I uh... I’m gonna go?”

Catra frowned in confusion before looking back at Adora realising how this must seem. Back when they were both in the Horde, being caught in a situation like this would make Catra shrink in on herself and a stubborn blush would shatter her natural defences. But not now. Now being caught in a seemingly steamy situation made her feel strong. Her smirk was back.

“No need, I was leaving anyway.” She grabbed Adora’s stupid hair poof forcing her head up. A flexing muscle in her jaw indicated that Adora was grinding her teeth together, something she would do during training when she was in pain but didn’t want to show it in fear of being seen as weak. Catra scoffed.

“I sure did miss our little catch-ups, Adora. Things are always a little more fun with you around.” Catra laughed and shoved Adora’s head away causing it to bang on the pole, a sharp hiss slipping form Adora’s lips. Catra walks away, a new-found confidence evident in her strides.

“Catra… Catra wait!” The strain in the blonde’s voice only amplifying Catra’s feeling of control. She takes the sword from Scorpia who has been watching the interaction with her eyebrows reaching her hairline.

Catra runs a slender finger over the blade of the sword throwing one last smirk at Adora who has started to struggle in her holdings again. Catra could get used to this.

“Let’s go have some fun.” Scorpia beams and opens the door for them. As the feline and the towering woman walk away from their prisoner, Catra can hear Adora cry out for her getting more and more desperate with every sound.

Yes. Catra could get very much used to this.

She Never Listens

Chapter Notes

> This chapter was written by my super talented wife-to-be. Any chapters that are from Adora's perspective will be written by her just to give the story that extra bit of zing
>
> Hope you enjoy:)

Adora twisted her wrists every which way in an attempt to escape her restraints.

"Catra!" she called again. The goon Catra had left to guard her rolled their eyes and went back to poking around the ship for spare loot. At least Huntara got Bow and Glimmer out, at least they were safe. It was amazing how strong Huntara was, she took several sedative darts and still managed to carry two whole people to safety. She also had incredible abs and thighs. They were distracting, the woman couldn't move without her muscles rippling. Adora told herself she was so interested because she was a little bit jealous. She wondered if she could look like that if she just trained a little harder…

Her hands were falling asleep. There was no way she could escape these knots if Catra didn't want her to. Catra had a way with rope. Momentarily defeated, Adora slumped against the pole she was tied to, looking up and imagining Glimmer materializing to save her. No, she couldn't wait for that. She wouldn't let her friends put themselves in more danger because of a stupid accident that was her fault. She arched her back against the post, futilely stretching her leg out to try to reach something, anything.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora snapped her head up to face her ex-best friend, who was wearing a coy smirk. Adora stared, trying to figure out what was different about this smirk. It was sharper, colder than the teasing

grin she remembered from before. Of course, it still had the same frustrating effect. Catra always knew how to get under Adora's skin, she probably practised how to make that face with her canine overlapping her bottom lip ever so slightly because she knew it would catch Adora's attention. Catra always had been cunning like that. She sent the guard away with an elegant (probably practised) nod of her delicate chin.

"Catra," (smug bitch), "You have to let me go."

Catra's smirk dropped and Adora felt her heart drop with it. Of course it would, Catra used to be her best friend. Seeing her friend smile had always been a pleasure for Adora.

"There's always something with you, isn't there Adora." Catra cupped Adora's cheek with a (probably painstakingly manicured) hand. Moons, the last time Catra had touched her like this…

"Now you're all mine, tell me your secrets."

Adora was lost in Catra's eyes like the sea and the sun as Catra's claws gently stroked her cheek. She forgot how tight Catra had tied the ropes around her.

"...and that's how I would gain information about the rebellion if I ever caught one of them," Catra explained to the instructor as she deftly untied Adora.

Behind them, Kyle's face was bright red, Lonnie looked tired, and Rogelio just looked disappointed. Adora rubbed the rope marks around her arms in a daze as Catra pulled her to her feet.

"Right, well, the Horde has other ways of getting answers, but nice try, Catra," the instructor droned.

"See the thing is, I don't have to do anything anyone tells me to anymore." As if Catra ever did anything anyone told her to do. She never listened to Adora. Not even when Adora begged her to leave the Horde and come with her.

When Catra called her an inconvenience, Adora sucked in a breath. That hurt and Catra knew it would. That's what Shadow Weaver would say to them.

"What are you going to do to me?" Adora made her voice hard so it didn't tremble. It wasn't that she was afraid of Catra, it just hurt so much to see her best friend so disgusted with her.

"Whatever the hell I want." Adora believed her. She knew nobody could tell Catra what to do, but she wished Catra would listen to her, just once.

"My friends will come back for me." At least, she hoped they would. "They'll stop you before you hand me over to Hordak. You know they will. We always stop you." Why wouldn't Catra just listen?

"Who said anything about giving you to Hordak?"

"What?" Was this… good news?

"Hordak will not lay a finger on you." Don't say that. It was Catra's own fault she stayed with the Horde. Or was it Adora's? Did Hordak do something to Catra?

"The Horde will not touch you. Neither will the rebellion. You are my prisoner. For once, I hold the upper hand. I have their almighty She-ra. You are mine." Adora almost choked on her own breath and her face flushed (because she almost choked). What could she say to that? She had been Catra's, Catra's best friend. And Catra had been hers. Did Catra still want that? Before Adora could come up with a snappy reply, Scorpia burst into the room. Before leaving with the other force captain, Catra pulled Adora's hair and said something in such an unusually confident tone that Adora didn't realize what was happening until Catra started to walk away.

"Catra...Catra wait!" Catra didn't wait. She closed the door and Adora was alone with the image of Catra's cruel eyes burned into her mind.

SCORPIA IS A SWEETHEART

Catra slouched upon her makeshift throne cradling She-ra's sword and admiring the party which was still in full swing several hours after her and Adora's conversation. She observed Scorpia as she chatted away with a beady eyed lizard woman who took a step back as Scorpia waved her pincers around enthusiastically. Catra allowed a small smile to creep upon her lips. As annoying and clingy as Scorpia was, she was very glad that they were both here together, both starting this new life together.

Scorpia looked over to Catra briefly, a small blush working its way from her ears to her cheeks. Catra was not oblivious to the feelings that the taller woman harboured for her. In fact, once or twice, Catra has taken those feelings and used them to her full advantage to get what she wanted. But she had decided there and then not to do that anymore, not to lead on her friend or use her in any way.

Scorpia had been nothing but kind to her, even when she didn't necessarily deserve it or even want it. But at the end of the day, Scorpia had stayed. Heck, she even asked Catra to stay which she fully intended to do.

"Catra," the raspy voice forced Catra's mis-matched eyes away from Scorpia and instead onto one of the many criminals she was now in charge of. Standing up from her slight bow, an act that made Catra's fur buzz with power, the criminal spoke making sure to avoid her leader's intense stare. "The prisoner is asking for you again."

Catra sighed dramatically but got up anyway, the sword now effortlessly resting on her shoulder. The sword was as heavy as ever. In fact, Catra's mind began to wander when she thought about how easy Adora was able to wield it, the strength that she knew Adora possessed. She shook her head, passing it off as a disappointed reaction.

“I better go shut her up, then.” The party parted as Catra made her way to Adora’s holding room.

Scorpia looked back at the throne Catra was previously perched upon only to find it empty. Her looming figure allowed her to easily survey the room for any sign of where her Wild Cat had got to. The last of a tail rounded a corner heading in the direction of Adora. Scorpia excused herself from the conversation she was having and race after her friend.

Catra reached the door leading to Adora but paused before opening it. She had spent the night putting off what she was going to do with her prisoner but now that she was about to face her again, she needed a game plan. But what?

She could use the almighty She-ra as a bargaining chip but for what? Since Catra has left the Horde, there is no need to for her to trade Adora for information. In fact, Catra couldn’t care less about the stupid war anymore. She was going to build her own kingdom away from all of that rubbish. A kingdom… she would need supplies to do that. That could be a plan?

Before Catra could develop the thought, Scorpia’s booming voice calling out for her from down the hallway startled her enough to nearly drop the sword.

“Catr -oh there you are!” Scorpia stopped right in front of Catra, panting slightly after bounding after her. Catra forcefully repressed a grimace remembering her personal agreement to treat her friend better.

Once she caught her breath Scorpia straighten back up, offering an apologetic smile.

“What do you want, Scorpia?” Catra does her best to control her slight aggravation at her little jump scare. If any seeped through her attempts, Scorpia doesn’t let on and instead continues talking as if they had been all night.

“So anyway, what are your plans for Adora?” The question is innocent enough, but frustration still bubbles on the surface of Catra’s fur. She hates that she no longer has a plan, or at least a coherent plan, for what she is going to do with the dumb blonde now. Part of her wants to keep her under lock and key, hers to torment however and whenever she wishes. On the other hand, Catra is fully aware of how valuable Adora is to both sides of the war. Something that she could easily use to become a leader in her own right. After all, that is the goal… right?

“I have some ideas.” Scorpia placed a gentle claw on Catra’s shoulder but it didn’t do much to comfort the young cat’s confusing intentions.

“You know Wild Cat, if you let me in a little,” Catra’s grip tightens on the sword but keeps her eyes locked with Scorpia’s, “I might be able to help.”

Shrugging the claw off of her shoulder, Catra lets out a low sigh. She knows that she should let Scorpia in on at least the beginnings of her plans. After all, Scorpia had given up just as much as either of them to be here. She wasn’t sent to die like Catra was, in fact, she was asked specifically not to accompany the feline. Yet here she was.

Defeated, Catra turns away. A slither of shame works its way into her words as she speaks.

“I don’t really have a plan.” Scorpia’s usual beaming smile falters a little. She almost missed Catra’s confession but she didn’t really care about that. It was how small and worried her Wild Cat sounded that made her tender heartbreak.

Scorpia knew that when she asked Catra to stay with her in the Crimson Waste, it would be asking her to put all of her plans and ambitions aside to create new ones. She never really stopped to think that maybe Catra didn’t know what she was going to do once she agreed to that. The Second in Command always seemed so on top of things, so controlled. At least when it came to

military plans, the feline's emotions were a whole other story. But the Catra that stood before her in the corridor of an empty, broken ship was not that woman she has become so attached to.

"Hey, that's okay. We can think of something!"

Turned away from Scorpia, Catra finally let go of the sneer she was trying to hold back. Scorpia just didn't get it. Catra has nothing left, nothing. Scorpia could go back to the Fright Zone any time she wish and be greeted with open arms. Well, maybe not open arms but she wouldn't be thrown into a cell. Catra did not have such a luxury. She needed a plan that would ensure her own safety, her own power. She needed immunity against Hordak's death wish he had for her as well as protection against any rebel attack. Whatever plan she thinks up, she needs to be certain of. She didn't have anything to fall back on. Scorpia did.

She-ra's sword was starting to dig into Catra's shoulder. As strong as she was, the sword was still super heavy and was starting to sear her leather jacket. The sword…

"Maybe we could get the gang to invade a nearby by village? You know for supplies and-"

"No." Catra cut of Scorpia's rambling, throwing her a sly look. "I have a better idea."

The Trade

The doors to Adora's holding room opened and Catra revelled in the sight before her. The former blonde soldier was dripping in sweat and panting heavily. It was clear that her attempts at escaping had yet to cease. Catra allowed herself to admire the woman's stamina, after all it had been several hours since the last spoke and it was safe to presume that the only thing Adora had been doing the entire time was trying to escape her confines. Trying to escape Catra. How adorable.

"Hey, Adora." Adora's head whipped up to the direction of the all too familiar voice, eyes wide.

"Catra…" Her name was simply a whisper but Catra heard it clear as day. She smirked.

"Got yourself quite worked up there, huh, Princess?" Making her way over to her captive, Catra leaned one hand on the pole over Adora's head easily towering over her. The difference in height didn't stop the warrior's eyes from keeping trained on the solider.

Not receiving a reply but instead a glare, Catra sighed. She gracefully sat on the floor in front of Adora, crossing her legs and getting herself comfortable. The sword lay haphazardly in her lap.

"You know, I have all day to play these games." She watched Adora's nose twitch in agitation. "But I doubt you want to play them. You always seem to lose."

"Not always," Adora mumbled. The faintest taint of pink dusted her cheeks before Catra watched her shake her head, loose strands of sweaty blonde hair framing her face.

Catra just continued to smirk at her captive knowing that the mighty warrior princess before her would break sooner or later and spill all those delicious secrets she was so desperate to tell.

After all, it was Adore who has been begging for Catra's attention for hours. Not the other way around.

Adora sighed, in defeat or frustration it was unclear, but either way she hung her head and her struggling stopped. Catra frowned at how easily her ex-best friend had given up. It usually took several minutes of her taunting to get through to the warrior but this time it took hardly any effort on Catra's part. It was nowhere near as satisfying as she had wanted it to be.

"Do you have any idea what you're doing by keeping me here?" There was an edge to Adora's words that Catra couldn't recognise but still made her feel like there was a dagger being carelessly shoved into her heart. "The people you're endangering? The problems you're causing?"

Catra refused to stifle her growl.

"You didn't seem to care about any of that when you left." *When you left me.* Adora lifted her head and gave Catra a look. The same stupid look she received back in Thaymor when Adora left for good. The same dumb look she was thrown as Adora hung from the ledge in the beacon. Catra hated that look.

"Catra I-"

"Save it." Catra took a deep breath and closed her eyes to curb the sizzling anger threatening to spill out of her. She will not lose control. When she opened her eyes again, Adora had replaced the apologetic look with one of worry. Catra wasn't sure which one she preferred. Regardless, Catra shot her guard back up and opted to hide the hurricane of emotions behind a cruel, unrelenting smirk. Suddenly Adora no longer seemed worried.

"What do you want Adora? I have a party to get back to." Catra examined her claws refusing to seem even a little bit interested in what Adora had to say when in fact she was very interested. Any information Adora gave her about... well anything would allow Catra's plan to succeed. The more she had to bargain with, the

more either the Rebels or the Horde may be willing to give her in return.

“Catra, you have to-” Hearing the start of a demand, Catra clashed her claws against the pole right next to Adora’s face, leaving jiggered tears. The action made the blonde shut her eyes tight preparing for the pain, but nothing came. When she opened her eyes again, Catra was up in her face with a wild glint in her eyes.

“How many times do I have to tell you, Princess. I don’t have to do anything anymore.” The two warriors could feel each other’s breaths on their lips. It would have been distracting to the feline has she not been so riled up. But she was, and she wanted nothing more than for Adora to hurt.

“Catra please just listen-“

“No, you listen! You have no power here. You have no control. You don’t get to call the shots anymore.” Catra’s breathing was heavy and her claws were at risk of being stuck if she sunk them any deeper into the pillar. Adora’s eyes were wide and slightly blurry to look at from how close their faces were making Catra feel dizzy. She took a deep breath and stood up straight, looking down her nose at her prisoner. “You are nothing to me.”

Adora looked hurt but Catra didn’t care. Okay, maybe she cared a little. But the blonde before her had taken everything from her. Her title, her power, her dignity… her best friend.

“If I'm nothing then why am I still here?” Catra picked up on the slight voice crack, but Adora continued anyway. “You have everything you want. You’re away from the Horde and you have the chance to rule a kingdom of your own. Why am I still here?”

Catra barked a bitter laugh. Oh, how little the Princess knew. The former second in command had nothing. She never got what she wanted, never. But that was about to change.

“Oh, Adora. You will be useful to me yet.” Toying with She-ra’s sword, Catra looked down with a smug smirk at the warrior. Adora only frowned and tugged at her bindings as Catra ran a slender finger along the edge of the sword. “You and this precious sword are my bargaining chips to get what I need. I’m sure either side of the war will pay a high price for She-ra.”

A deep, unnatural growl caused Catra to raise a brow.

“Do you have any idea what will happen If Hordak gets my sword?” Catra’s lip twitched a reaction that didn’t go unnoticed as Adora corrected herself. “She-ra’s sword?”

“I don’t care about your prissy stories. I have a kingdom to build.”

Before Catra could even fully turn her body to leave, Adora was tugging on the ropes again, her voice straining as she rushes out presumably another useless excuse.

“Catra wait!” Rolling her eyes and groaning, Catra turned around with an expectant look. “If Hordak gets the sword and opens the portal you won’t get to build anything.” Catra remained neutral but Adora continued pleading. “Hordak, he's planning on bringing the rest of the Horde army through a portal, he’s going to destroy everything. Catra please we can’t let that happen.”

Catra took a moment to process what the blonde was going on about. The feline is far from dumb. She knows that if that portal opens and more Horde soldiers are brought to Etheria, she will not stand a chance of building her Kingdom. But then again, if what Adora is saying is true, then this sword was more valuable than she originally thought. Maybe Hordak would be desperate enough to… no. No. Catra will not go back to that. She will lead, she will have power.

“How exactly do you know this?” Catra’s voice was steady, careful. Hordak had not entirely entrusted his second in command with his whole bigger picture plan yet so how on Etheria could the rebellion know? Unless…

“You don’t know?” Catra hated how cautious sounded. It only confirmed her suspicions. She whipped around and grabbed the blonde’s collar, pulling their faces close once again. This time, Catra was not messing around. This was no game. She needed answers.

“What don’t I know?” Her grip tightened on the collar.

“Catra… Shadow Weaver is in Brightmoon.” Catra only heard a high pitch ringing bounding around her skull. Shadow Weaver left her. Left her for Adora. It is always Adora. Even after everything Catra had done it was Adora, *Adora, ADORA.*

The blonde warrior was talking, or at least that’s what Catra presumed by the moving of her lips and the struggle to break free once again. There was a hot prickling behind her eyes but Catra was not about to give in. She was not weak, not anymore. One too many times has Shadow Weaver been the source of Catra’s outbursts. No more.

“It’s always you.” Adora stopped whatever she was rattling on about, finally able to lean back a little as Catra let go of her collar. “Shadow Weaver left me, for you.” There was a dangerous edge to Catra’s words. Good. She was no longer a scared child, trailing in the shadows of Adora. She was a ruler. A leader. She was worth more than anyone thought she could ever be worth. She was more than Adora was.

Catra left the room without another word. She had a plan and nothing Adora was going to say could stop it from happening. She will get her Kingdom, she will prove her worth and she will have her own slice of paradise. She deserves it, she wants it and she will have it.

……
……..

Catra returned not long after, now with Scorpia in tow. It seems as though Adora never stopped fighting, obviously having spent

the little time between Catra's wordless departure and her smug arrival trying to escape. However, as soon as the door slid open again, her attempts paused.

"Catra-"

"Gag her." Scorpia wordlessly obliged only offering Adora an apologetic look as a dirty gag cut off any of the blonde's attempts at pleading with Catra. The feline had her back to the warrior, fiddling with a tracker pad until the display was projected onto one of the ship's screens.

"Hey uh Catra, not to doubt your leadership or anything," Catra glared over her shoulder at Scorpia who was scratching the back of her neck with a giant pincer. The nerves of what she was about to say rolled off of her giant body in waves, something Catra felt bad about. She desperately wanted to soften her glare but refused to let her guard down in front of her prisoner. "Yeah uh just are you sure this is the best option?"

Catra glanced over at Adora for the first time since re-entering the room. She smiled making sure to put as much aggression behind it as possible before turning her attention back to her teddy bear of a friend.

"Yes. We will show all of them just how powerful we are."

"Yeah but-"

"But nothing." Catra took a deep breath to calm her aggravation. She had lost count of how many times Scorpia had raised her concern for the plan that she had come up with but she knew it was just because the former force captain cared about her. Cared about the new life they were starting. Cared about doing it right. "There's nothing to worry about, Scorpia. We have She-ra," out of the corner of her eye, Catra saw Adora flinch at the sour note tied to She-ra's name. "We have the upper hand. They will play by our rules."

Seemingly having nothing more to say, Catra threw a very quick, very small reassuring smile to Scorpia before pressing a button on her tacker pad. Adora pulled against her binds, seeing on the larger screen who Catra was calling and trying with everything she had to shout through her gag. Catra only chuckled to herself, ears straining to hear the muffled sounds. They were heavenly.

"Catra." The almost robotic but extremely cutting voice of Hordak echoed through the chamber. Catra refused to show any kind of reaction to the venom that dripped off of his tongue as Hordak spat her name. "I sent you there to die and yet you struggle to manage that. Typical. Shadow Weaver always said-"

"Are you done?" Even Scorpia gasped at the disrespectful interruption. After all, Hordak the nightmarish threat that every soldier feared in their childhood. A sharp growl but nothing more signalled for Catra to continue.

"I have something you need, and you have something I need. I propose a trade."

"How dare you! You are a soldier of the Horde. You were sent on a mission and you will deliver my goods for nothing in return but your very life! You owe me." Catra couldn't contain herself anymore. With an uncontrollable rage, her voice matched Hordak's booming echoes.

"You sent me to die. I owe you nothing." Catra took a deep breath, straightening up out of the hunched over defensive position she subconsciously found herself in. She ran a hand through the wild hair before continuing. "You need She-ra's sword to open the portal. It's the only thing on Etheria powerful enough to power something like that." Catra was lying through her teeth. She had no clue if it was the most powerful thing on Etheria but she needed to push the importance of the sword to get what she wanted.

"Oh yes, that would make sense! We need She-ra's sword. It all makes sense now!" A mass of purple fluttered across the screen

as Entrapta ran around Hordak's lab doing hell knows what. Catra didn't care. She kept her eyes trained on Hordak who was yet to break his silence.

There was a brief silence that was only filled with Entrapta's tinkering ringing through the trackerpad and Adora's relentless struggle to escape. The blonde would not stop her attempts at trying to plead with Catra through the gag. Something that did not go unnoticed by Hordak who broke the staring competition he was having with Catra to take in the sweaty blonde just visible behind the feline.

"Is She-ra herself included in this trade?" The question caught Catra off guard as she felt her brow involuntarily furrow. She whipped her head around and her eyes crashed into Adora's pleading look. Catra snarled.

"No. She is not," she turned back to Hordak who only look disappointed. "She-ra stays with me. You only need the sword." Despite the finality to her words, Hordak still had the galls to chuckle darkly.

"Oh, you stupid child. The rebellion runs on hope and hope alone. If we are to make this trade worthwhile, their beacon needs to be crushed. They need to see their only flicker of hope die before them." Catra's heart felt like it was in a boxing match with her ribs. "I have to kill She-ra."

"No." The word tumbled out of Catra's mouth before she could stop it. But having now said it, the feline needed to stand her ground. She was not a naive child, she knew what she was saying. Control. She was in control. "She-ra is mine and I will do as I wish with her. You will have the sword. She-ra will stay here."

Once again, Hordak only chuckled which frustrated Catra to no end.

"Well, then you leave me with no choice. You better get whatever pathetic excuse of a defence you have ready, Catra. I will have the

sword. I will have She-ra. I will crush you.” And with that, the call was cut. The room fell silent. No trade was made, the plan had failed.

Catra slowly turned to the only other people in the room. While both women were wide-eyed it appeared to be for different reasons. Scorpia’s held so much worry and uncertainty while Adora’s was almost unreadable. Almost. Catra could read Adora better than anyone else, even after all this time apart and what she was picking up from the blonde now made her both want to gag and cry. Pride.

Broken Bonds

Chapter Notes

> Yo, this is doing so freaking well and I've gotten so many positive responses which I was not expecting so thank you so freaking much!

It had been a good few moments since the call with Hordak has dropped and the only sound that could be heard in the empty ship was Catra’s ragged breathing. Even Adora had stopped trying to escape and instead was looking at Catra with that odd look that caused the feline's stomach to churn.

Trading She-ra’s sword for supplies was the only plan Catra had. The only hope of making something of herself away from the war, away from what she has become. But she failed. What on Etheria was she going to do now?

“Wildcat...” Scorpia’s tone was far too cautious for Catra’s liking, speaking to her as if she may break at any minute. Maybe that was true. “Are you… It’s going to be okay.” How can she say that? Catra had risked everything attempting to make that trade with Hordak and now the Horde will be here any minute to destroy the last of anything she owned. Adora included. Adora…

The blonde had yet to take her eyes off of her ex-best friend. Catra turned her attention to her captive trying her best to keep her emotions in check. The former second in command was not entirely sure why she was so quick to say no when Hordak asked for She-ra to be included in the trade. Of course, when he revealed that his plan was to kill her, Catra applauded her quick tongue but she still could not understand why the answer came to her with such speed.

Maybe it was nostalgia. Maybe it was her own selfish need to deal with Adora herself. But looking into the baby blue eyes of the warrior on her knees before her, Catra knew it was none of the

above. She said no because she could not lose Adora again. She will not lose Adora again. Her eyes narrowed with determination.

"Scorpia," the giant teddy bear jumped to attention at the sudden noise. "Tell the gang to get ready to move out. We aren't safe here anymore."

"But what about- "one look at the feline's new determination stopped Scorpia from finishing the sentence as she rushed out of the room to follow up on the command.

Taking a breath and digging her claws into her hands, Catra stroke over to Adora who had yet to resume her attempts at escaping.

A slightly fearful look crossed the blonde's face as Catra knelt down so that they were at the same level. The look was soon replaced with confusion as the gag was removed.

Neither women spoke but just stared at each other, trying to figure out what the other was thinking. Seemingly satisfied with Adora's silence, Catra reached around to cut the ropes with her claws, causing Adora to lean forward a little and almost into the brunette's lap.

Quickly regaining her composure, Adora straightened up but remained kneeling as though she was still tied up. Catra watched her carefully.

"What are you doing?" Even though her voice was low and almost a whisper, a flick of Catra's ear told the blonde that she was clearly heard.

Catra leaned back onto her heels, fists clenched in her lap.

"I'm not going to let you die." Adora scoffed.

"Haven't you literally been trying to kill me for-"

"Adora." Catra's tone, while holding a clear warning, was soft shutting Adora up straight away. She could not remember the last

time her former friend had been this vulnerable around her. Even back in the Horde towards the end of Adora's time there, Catra's guard was up 24/7.

There was a pause. Catra was aware of how weak she looked right now. How vulnerable and open she was allowing herself to be. But whatever friendship her and Adora had was long gone and she needed to reignite just a little bit of that to keep herself safe. To keep her leadership safe. To keep Adora safe.

"I…" Catra couldn't maintain their eye contact anymore, opting to look to her hands instead. "You have to come with me."

Adora took a moment to reply, her voice steady and lacking any note of playfulness.

"Why would I do that?"

"Because-"Catra bit her tongue. Why would Adora come with her? She had no reason to. She no longer tied up and could walk out Catra's reach whenever she felt like it. No, not again. Catra won't let her leave again. "Because I need you."

The feline refused to look up but could feel Adora staring at her. This was stupid, Catra shouldn't need anyone. Had she not learnt anything in the Horde? And of course, Adora didn't need her. She had left. She had her new friends. She-

"Okay." Catra felt her body freeze at the simplicity of the word, her trembling hands steady. Any thought that invaded her mind that she had imagined the blonde's response was abolished as soon as a soft, pale pair of hands placed themselves over her clenched fists. This gave Catra to life her head, meeting the tender look Adora was giving her.

"What?" Even though Catra had muttered the word to herself, Adora still chuckled a little, biting her lip to try to stop herself. Catra didn't mind.

“I said okay, dummy. I’ll go with you.” Gently prising Catra’s fists apart, Adora kept her hold on the other clammy hands. “But Catra, you can’t just run away from this.” Catra went to make a snarky comment but Adora got there first. “I know. I know I ran away. But my problems are mine and they follow where ever I go.”

Catra scrawled and looked down again only to have her head lifted by a gentle finger under her chin.

“We have to deal with this Catra.” We.

“I know I know just… we can’t stay here. Hordak will track the signal back to the ship and I’m not will to let innocent,” Adora raised a brow, “random people get hurt because I couldn’t do one simple thing.” Catra’s hand were trembling again. “I’m their leader, Adora. I’m responsible for them.”

This seemed to hit a nerve in Adora that Catra wasn’t aware existed as the blonde tightened her grip on the shaking hands.

“I know. We will keep them safe Catra.” Even though it wasn’t explicitly said, there was a promise behind Adora’s words. Catra wasn’t sure she believed her, after all since when did Adora make good on her promises? But then again what choice did Catra have?

“I need to let my friends know I’m okay.” Catra’s breath caught in her throat. For a short while, it felt like just them against the world, but with the mention of the blonde’s new friends, Catra realised that the daydream they had as kids was just that. A dream.

Catra snatched her hands away watching the softer pair chase after them before dropping back to Adora’s lap. The feline stood up towering over the blonde but this time Adora was able to stand up having a slight height advantage.

“They could help-“

“I doubt that. They couldn’t even last a day out here before being ambushed.”

Adora crossed her arms and huffed.

“Yeah well, whose fault is that? Besides, it was just three of us. I’m sure if I could just let them know what’s happening, the others would come and help.”

Catra lost it.

“Oh yeah and then what? I know you all hate me! Why would the prissy little princesses get their manicured hands dirty just to help the former Second in command of the ‘Evil Horde’?”

“I never hated you!”

Catra was taken back. She had convinced herself that after the temple Adora would never care for her again. In fact, it was part of the reason that she left the warrior hanging onto the ledge. Catra wanted her to stop caring if only to make it easier for the solider to sink her claws into She-ra’s back. If she thought that her former friend hated her, it would have made fighting a war against her so much easier. But of course, it didn’t work out that way. If anything, it had the exact opposite effect. Catra was filled to burst with guilt.

Yet here Adora was, confirming what Catra was too scared to know.

The door opened before either of them could say anything else. Scorpia stood awkwardly, balancing the sword on her shoulder, having clearly intruded on a heated conversation. It seemed that Scorpia was doing that a lot recently, but this time Catra was thankful for the intrusion. She was not quite sure how to respond to Adora’s confession simply because she had absolutely no clue how to feel about it.

“Everyone is packing up ready to move out.”

“Thank you Scorpia.” Scorpia beamed at the gratitude that Catra so very rarely gave but the smile quickly faded as she looked between the two women. Adora refused to meet her gaze and Catra had her fists clenched at her sides.

“Soooo uh..” Not quite knowing what to do, Scorpia decided it was best to leave the former friends to it. She wanted to stay in the room just in case something happened after all Adora was free now and was easily strong enough without Sher-ra to hurt her Wild Cat. But Scorpia trusted Catra and if Catra had released her prisoner from her restraints then she has to believe that the feline knew what she was doing.

“Scorpia?” Twirling on her heel, Scorpia offered Catra a small smile. Catra wordlessly approached her larger friend, taking the sword away and effortlessly holding it in front of her. Scorpia only watched on puzzled as Catra carried the sword over to Adora. The feline stopped far enough away that she didn’t have to touch the blonde but close enough so that it was clear the sword was for the taking.

“If you’re coming with us, you might as well be useful.”

Adora carefully took the sword from Catra, the cool metal offering a familiar sense of calm. Catra just scrawled rolling her eyes at the small smile threatening to cover the blonde’s face.
Before Adora could say thank you or anything else just as sappy, Catra was walking away towards the door. She stopped at the doorway looking over the shoulder expectantly, making Adora jump to attention and follow Scorpia and Catra through the ship, preparing to face the band of criminals she has promised to protect. Just another group of people to add to her ever-growing list of responsibilities.

Still, Adora didn’t mind the added weight to her shoulders. She was doing this for Catra, nobody else. That was reason enough.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!